

Fall 2026 weekday bus requirement: fleet certification

To: MBTA Board of Directors From: Service Planning, schedule certification Date: 5 October 2026

Certified requirement

The Board should certify the Fall 2026 weekday bus requirement at **621 buses**, +14 against the Summer 2026 certification of 607. The peak falls in the morning, at 07:51; the Summer peak fell at 07:59. The same files and the same convention reproduce the Summer certification of 607 exactly. Finance's draft peak of 521 is not certified. The schedule behind the fleet change is a net +321 weekday trips, 12,721 to 13,042, which is Finance's figure and is certified; the planners' +149 is not. **Route 65** (Brighton Center - Ruggles Station) is the single route behind the biggest share of the change at +45 trips.

The three figures, what each counted, and the certification decision

Finance's peak of 521 buses: not certified. It is the most trips underway at one moment, at 17:26 in the afternoon (the Summer equivalent is 513 at 17:26). Under the convention a bus is in service from the first departure to the last arrival of its day's work, so a bus on layover between trips is still out. Trips underway run about a hundred below buses out and peak in the afternoon, when trips are long, not in the morning, when the most buses are out.

Finance's +321 weekday trips: certified. It compares the weekday schedule that ran for most of the Summer rating (12,721 trips, the no school weekday, 34 of the rating's 48 Monday to Thursday dates) with the weekday schedule that runs for most of the Fall rating (13,042 trips, 41 of 44 dates from 28 September). That is the convention's certification day for each rating, and the figure stands.

The planners' +149: not certified. It replaces the Summer certification day with the Summer rating's school day weekday (12,893 trips, 10 of 48 dates, the weeks either side of the school holiday) to make a like for like school day comparison with Fall. The comparison is arithmetically correct and it is not the Board's convention, which certifies each rating on the schedule it mostly ran. On the planners' basis the Summer peak would be 615 buses, which does not reproduce the certified 607; the certified figures are not adjusted.

How the certified figures were built

The archive index assigns the feed published 12 August 2026 to 19 August, the Summer certification day, and the published Fall feed (the archive's 25 September entry) to 30 September, the Fall certification day. The Summer rating's Monday to Thursday dates split 34 on the no school weekday schedule, 10 on the school day schedule and 4 on transition variants, read from the June feed, whose calendar carries the whole rating from 14 June; the August feed's calendar starts on 12 August and alone would understate how long the no school schedule ran. The Fall rating runs one weekday schedule on 41 of 44 dates. Both days carry no holiday, modified or reduced service. Services were taken by date rather than by rating label. The route population is every route the feed classifies as Frequent, Local, Coverage, Commuter or Supplemental Bus; rail replacement shuttles are excluded and none ran on either day. Each trip was assigned to its block, each block counted as one bus from its first departure to its last arrival, and the count taken at every minute. Every figure is identical on every other qualifying day of its rating and in every archived feed that covers it.

Buses on the road at the peak, by route

At the Fall peak minute, 07:51, **Route 111** (Woodlawn - Haymarket Station) has the most buses on the road, **18**, ahead of Route 66 at 16. Of the 621 buses in service at that minute, **118 are between trips** and 503 are on a trip; each bus between trips is attributed to the route of the trip it has just completed. At the Summer peak minute, 07:59, Route 111 led with 18 and 133 buses were between trips. The full allocation for every route is in `peak_buses_by_route.csv`, and the route rows add up to 607 and 621.

The ten largest route changes in weekday trips (59 of 152 routes changed)

Rank	Route	Category	Summer	Fall	Change
1	65	Local Bus	86	131	+45
2	465	Local Bus	0	32	+32
3	66	Frequent Bus	216	247	+31
4	70	Local Bus	147	172	+25

Rank	Route	Category	Summer	Fall	Change
5	222	Local Bus	62	83	+21
6	220	Local Bus	62	81	+19
7	39	Frequent Bus	215	229	+14
8	32	Frequent Bus	289	302	+13
9	429	Local Bus	39	51	+12
10	SLW	Frequent Bus	63	53	-10
All bus routes 152 routes			12,721	13,042	+321

The 59 changed routes sum to +321; the other 93 bus routes run the same number of weekday trips under both ratings.

Route 65: what changed

Under the Summer rating 22 buses carry Route 65 trips during the weekday; under the Fall rating 33 do. Summer service ran 86 trips with the first departure at 05:58 and the last arrival at 21:03; Fall runs 131 trips from 05:00 to 25:33 (01:33 the next morning). The route was extended at its inbound end: Summer inbound trips end at Kenmore (headsign Kenmore) and Fall inbound trips end at Ruggles (headsign Ruggles), with the span opening about an hour earlier and closing more than four hours later. The added trips come from the longer span and more frequent service through the day, not from the Brighton Center end.

How close the driving route is to being overtaken

Route 465 (Danvers Square - Salem Depot via Liberty Tree Mall) is the runner up at +32, 13 trips behind, with Route 66 next at +31. The smallest change in a single route's Fall trip count that would make a different route the driver is **14 trips**: Route 465 at 46 Fall trips (+46), or Route 65 at 117 (+31), which would put Route 465 first.

Why no other figure survives

The convention fixes the unit, the day type, the day of week band, the population and the certification day, and the feed fixes which services run on each date and which trips share a bus. Applied together they give one Summer profile and one Fall profile, stable across every qualifying day and every archived feed, and the Summer profile returns the certified 607 exactly. Every other figure relaxes one fixed point: trips underway instead of buses out, the school day weeks instead of the schedule that ran the rating, a rating label instead of a date, or a Friday. 621 buses, +14, is the only requirement the convention and the files allow.